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Accessibility checklist

Your quick guide to basic web and app accessibility compliance.

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Accessibility checklist

Digital accessibility compliance means making sure your website and applications can be accessed and used by people with disabilities and the assistive technologies they use to navigate the web. This extends to customer portals, third-party site components, mobile applications, and any other ways your users and customers interact with your organization via the internet.

How do you know if your web and app content is accessible?

To determine if your organization's sites and applications are accessible, you need to perform automated and manual accessibility testing against web accessibility standards and any applicable regulations. The US and international standard for accessibility is WCAG (Web Content Accessibility Guidelines). This checklist is based on WCAG standards.

DID YOU KNOW? WCAG serves as the basis for accessibility regulations worldwide, including the US, Canada, the UK, the EU, Australia, and Japan. WCAG is developed by the World Wide Web Consortium (W3C).

The 5 major categories of disability

- **Visual:** Includes blind, low-vision, and color blind.
- **Speech:** Includes people who are not able to speak.
- **Hearing:** Includes deaf and hard of hearing.
- **Motor:** Includes people who are not able to use a mouse.
- **Cognitive:** Includes dyslexia, ADD, and epilepsy.

> "The power of the web is in its universality. Access by everyone regardless of disability is an essential aspect."
>
> —Tim Berners-Lee, W3C founder, inventor of the World Wide Web

Testing for accessibility

Color

1. Is color alone used to convey important information?
   - **How to check:** View the page in grayscale. Can you still understand all the information and perform all page functions?
   - **Primarily benefits:** Colorblind and low vision
   - **Requirement:** SC 1.4.1 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

2. Is the color contrast of text readable by people with low vision?
   - **How to check:** Run Axe DevTools. Fix any issues related to color contrast.
   - **Primarily benefits:** Colorblind and low vision
   - **Requirement:** SC 1.4.3 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

Images

3. Do all images have alt text?
   - **How to check:** Run Axe DevTools. Fix any issues related to missing alternate text.
   - **Primarily benefits:** Blind
   - **Requirement:** SC 1.1.1 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

4. Does the alternative text make sense?
   - **How to check:** If you replaced every image with the alt text, would you still have access to all meaningful information in those images?
   - **Primarily benefits:** Blind
   - **Requirement:** SC 1.1.1 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

5. If the image is a link, does the alt text clearly identify the link destination?
   - **How to check:** If you replaced the active image with the alt text, would you still understand the purpose of that link?
   - **Primarily benefits:** Blind
   - **Requirement:** SC 1.1.1 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

Images cont.

6. Are all CSS background images either pure decoration or do they have alternate text?
   - **How to check:** If you hide all background images, do you still have access to all information and functionality?
   - **Primarily benefits:** Blind
   - **Requirement:** SC 1.1.1 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

7. Is any text embedded in images?
   - **How to check:** Are any images used to present text? (See WCAG 2.x SC 1.4.5 for exceptions.)
   - **Primarily benefits:** Blind and low vision
   - **Requirement:** SC 1.4.5 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

Keyboard

8. Does the tab order make sense?
   - **How to check:** If you tab through the page using only your keyboard, is the navigation order logical and intuitive?
   - **Primarily benefits:** Keyboard users (typically people with visual and/or motor disabilities)
   - **Requirement:** SC 2.4.3 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

9. Can you always see where the keyboard focus is?
   - **How to check:** As you tab through the page using keyboard alone, can you always see which element on the page has focus?
   - **Primarily benefits:** Keyboard users
   - **Requirement:** SC 2.4.7 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2, SC 1.4.11 in WCAG 2.1, 2.2.

10. Does the user have access to the full functionality of the page or application using a keyboard alone?
   - **How to check:** Can you use every interactive aspect of a web page relying on your keyboard alone (no mouse)?
   - Is all information or functionality that would typically be triggered with a mouse accessible and operable with a keyboard alone?
   - **Primarily benefits:** Keyboard users
   - **Requirement:** SC 2.1.1 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

Form Fields

11. Do all form fields have appropriate labels?
    - **How to check:** Run Axe DevTools. Fix any issues related to labels.
    - **Primarily benefits:** Blind
    - **Requirement:** SC 1.3.1 and 4.1.2 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

Screen Reader

12. Is all content and functionality available to a screen reader?
    - **How to check:** When using a screen reader (with your eyes closed), do you have access to all information and features on the page, and can you complete all tasks independently?
    - **Primarily benefits:** Blind
    - **Requirement:** SC 1.1.1, 1.3.1, 2.1.1, 2.4.3, and 4.1.2 in WCAG 2.0, 2.1, 2.2

PRO TIP! Screen readers are an important tool for performing manual accessibility testing. If you're a Windows user, we recommend downloading the free NVDA screen reader built by NV Access. If you're on a Mac, you've already got a screen reader called VoiceOver installed on your machine. You can access it through the Accessibility menu in System Preferences or by pressing command-F5. VoiceOver is on iPhone as well, and if you're on an Android phone, you can use TalkBack.

Start today!

The most efficient, cost-effective, and low-stress approach to accessibility compliance is a proactive approach. Get started with world-class tools and expert guidance today: www.deque.com.

